Hussain Mohammed Ershad as chief of army staff helped Vice President Abdus Sattar take over as acting president of Bangladesh after Zia's assassination. Sattar promised to hold elections soon. In November 1981, Sattar scored a landslide victory for the BNP. But within a few months, in March 1982, Mohammed Ershad executed a bloodless coup, ending Ziaur Rahman's legacy. A R&AW report said that such a move had been in the offing since the assassination of Ziaur Rahman in 1981. The report said:

The development leading to army take over can be traced ultimately to President Zia's assassination. That episode removed most important leaders of the liberation wing in the Bangladesh army, one or two remaining senior Generals were eased out within two or three weeks, leaving the leadership entirely in the hands of repatriate group. The period between May and November 1981, when Sattar was acting President, was used to project Zia's party BNP as the only force which could run the country. Most of the officers involved in the assassination were tried and executed. During this period, the BNP appeared to present a united front under Sattar. Army Chief Ershad also appeared to be co-operative. The November Presidential election brought out the dangers in the situation. Since Sheikh Hasina was too young to contest, Kamal Hossain was the Awami League candidate. Both the sides made charges of rigging. The election campaign was violent. There were also strikes in many sectors of industry and government—altogether a very unconvincing election. However, Sattar's majority appears to have been genuine. The process of legitimisation does not seem to have helped Sattar. His first cabinet was a weak compromise in which balance between the right and the left in the BNP was upset. The Prime Minister, Shah Azizur Rehman, belongs to right wing, originally Muslim